

Introduction to University Mathematics

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Abstract

Notes for the University of Helsinki course MAT11001, taught in Finnish from 31.08.2026–17.10.2026.

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1 Course information

The official course information is available on the University of Helsinki course page.

2 Lecture notes

2.1 31.08.2026

The first lecture was mostly spent going over the course structure and other general admin topics. We did go over some preliminary definitions and examples, which will follow.

2.1.1 Notational conventions

Definition 2.1. An integer $p > 1$ is *prime* if its only positive divisors are 1 and p .

Definition 2.2. The following basic sets of numbers will be used throughout:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{N} &= \{0, 1, 2, \dots\} \\ \mathbb{Z} &= \{\dots, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, \dots\} \\ \mathbb{Z}^+ &= \mathbb{N} \setminus \{0\} \\ \mathbb{Q} &= \left\{ \frac{p}{q} : p, q \in \mathbb{Z}, q \neq 0 \right\} \\ \mathbb{R} &= \text{the set of real numbers} \\ \mathbb{C} &= \{a + bi : a, b \in \mathbb{R}\}, \quad i^2 = -1 \\ \mathbb{P} &= \{p \in \mathbb{Z} : p \text{ is prime}\}\end{aligned}$$

2.1.2 Principle of mathematical induction

Here we state the fundamental principle of mathematical induction without proof, and use it freely thereafter.

Theorem 2.3 (Principle of mathematical induction). *Let $n_0 \in \mathbb{N}$, and let $P(n)$ be a statement for each $n \in \mathbb{N}$ with $n \geq n_0$. Suppose that*

1. $P(n_0)$ is true, and
2. for every $n \geq n_0$, $P(n)$ implies $P(n+1)$.

Then $P(n)$ is true for every $n \geq n_0$.

Proof. Omitted. □

Example 2.4. We prove by induction that

$$\sum_{k=1}^n k = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$$

for every integer $n \geq 1$.

For $n = 1$, the identity holds because

$$\sum_{k=1}^1 k = 1 = \frac{1(1+1)}{2}.$$

Now suppose that the identity holds for some integer $n \geq 1$. Then

$$\begin{aligned}\sum_{k=1}^{n+1} k &= \sum_{k=1}^n k + (n+1) \\ &= \frac{n(n+1)}{2} + (n+1) \\ &= \frac{(n+1)(n+2)}{2}.\end{aligned}$$

Thus the identity also holds for $n+1$, and hence for every integer $n \geq 1$. $\square$

2.2 03.09.2026

2.2.1 Divisibility of integers

We start by defining the precise meaning of *even* and *odd* numbers.

Definition 2.5. A number $m \in \mathbb{Z}$ is *even* if there exists $k \in \mathbb{Z}$ such that

$$m = 2k.$$

On the other hand, m is *odd* if there exists a $k \in \mathbb{Z}$ such that

$$m = 2k + 1.$$

Definition 2.6 (Divisibility). A number $a \in \mathbb{Z}$ is said to be *divisible* by a number $b \in \mathbb{Z}, b \neq 0$, if there exists a $k \in \mathbb{Z}$ such that

$$a = kb.$$

In this case we also say that b *divides* a , and write

$$b \mid a.$$

If b does *not* divide a , we write

$$b \nmid a.$$

Definition 2.7. For $n \in \mathbb{Z} \setminus \{0\}$, we denote the set of integers that are divisible by n by

$$n\mathbb{Z} = \{z \in \mathbb{Z} : z = nk, \quad k \in \mathbb{Z}\}.$$

2.2.2 Strong induction

In some proofs it is useful to assume all preceding cases rather than only the immediately preceding case. This gives an equivalent form of the principle of induction, called *strong induction*.

Theorem 2.8 (Strong induction). *Let $n_0 \in \mathbb{N}$, and let $P(n)$ be a statement for each $n \in \mathbb{N}$ with $n \geq n_0$. Suppose that*

1. $P(n_0)$ is true, and

2. for every $n \geq n_0$, if $P(k)$ is true for every k with $n_0 \leq k \leq n$, then $P(n+1)$ is true.

Then $P(n)$ is true for every $n \geq n_0$.

Proof. Omitted. □

As an example where strong induction is natural, let us prove that all natural numbers $n \geq 2$ can be written as a product of *prime* numbers.

Theorem 2.9. *Every natural number $n \geq 2$ can be written as a product of prime numbers.*

Proof. When $n = 2$, we have $n \in \mathbb{P}$, so the result holds trivially. Now suppose $n \geq 2$ and the statement holds for all $2 \leq k \leq n$. If $n+1 \in \mathbb{P}$, the result holds trivially, so suppose $n+1 \notin \mathbb{P}$. Then we have

$$n+1 = ab,$$

for some $2 \leq a, b \leq n$. By the induction hypothesis, a and b can be written as products of primes, so

$$\begin{aligned} a &= p_1 p_2 \cdots p_i, & p_1, \dots, p_i &\in \mathbb{P}, \\ b &= q_1 q_2 \cdots q_j, & q_1, \dots, q_j &\in \mathbb{P}. \end{aligned}$$

Thus we have

$$n+1 = ab = p_1 p_2 \cdots p_i q_1 q_2 \cdots q_j.$$

The result follows from Theorem 2.8. □

2.2.3 Sequences

Definition 2.10. A sequence of real numbers is a function $z: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, whose terms are denoted by $z_n = z(n)$. We write the sequence as

$$(z_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}} = (z_0, z_1, z_2, \dots).$$

Definition 2.11. A sequence of real numbers may also be specified recursively. First, for some $k \in \mathbb{Z}^+$, we define the initial terms $z_0, \dots, z_{k-1}$. For each $n \geq k$, we then define z_n in terms of earlier terms $z_0, \dots, z_{n-1}$.

2.3 07.09.2026

This lecture was mostly spent going through basic mathematical notation.

2.3.1 Logical connectives

Definition 2.12. Let p and q be propositions. We define the following logical connectives:

1. The *conjunction* $p \wedge q$, read “ p and q ”, is true exactly when both p and q are true.

2. The *disjunction* $p \vee q$, read “ p or q ”, is true exactly when at least one of p and q is true.
3. The *implication* $p \implies q$, read “ p implies q ”, is false exactly when p is true and q is false.
4. The *equivalence* $p \iff q$, read “ p if and only if q ”, is true exactly when p and q have the same truth value.
5. The *negation* $\neg p$, read “not p ”, is true exactly when p is false.

Definition 2.13. Let p and q be propositions.

1. The *negated implication* $p \nRightarrow q$, read “ p does not imply q ”, is true exactly when p is true and q is false.
2. The *negated equivalence* $p \nLeftrightarrow q$, read “ p is not equivalent to q ”, is true exactly when p and q have different truth values.

Definition 2.14. Let X be a set. A *predicate* $P(x)$ on X is a statement containing a variable x whose truth value depends on the chosen value of $x \in X$. For each $a \in X$, substituting a for x gives the proposition $P(a)$, which is either true or false. For example, $P(x) := x > 0$ is a predicate on $\mathbb{R}$; $P(2)$ is true, whereas $P(-1)$ is false.

Definition 2.15. Let $P(x)$ be a predicate on a set X .

1. The *universal quantification* $\forall x \in X: P(x)$, read “for every $x \in X$, $P(x)$ ”, is true exactly when $P(a)$ is true for every $a \in X$.
2. The *existential quantification* $\exists x \in X: P(x)$, read “there exists an $x \in X$ such that $P(x)$ ”, is true exactly when $P(a)$ is true for at least one $a \in X$.

Definition 2.16. The *negated existential quantification* $\nexists x \in X: P(x)$, read “there does not exist an $x \in X$ such that $P(x)$ ”, is true exactly when $P(a)$ is false for every $a \in X$. Equivalently,

$$\nexists x \in X: P(x) \iff \forall x \in X: \neg P(x).$$

2.3.2 Basic set theory

Definition 2.17. A *set* is a collection of distinct objects, called its *elements*. If an object x is an element of a set A , we write $x \in A$; otherwise, we write $x \notin A$. The order in which the elements are listed, and any repetition among them, do not affect the set.

Definition 2.18. Two sets A and B are *equal*, written $A = B$, if they have exactly the same elements. Equivalently,

$$A = B \iff \forall x: (x \in A \iff x \in B).$$

Definition 2.19. The *empty set* is the set containing no elements. It is denoted by $\emptyset$.

Definition 2.20. Let A and B be sets. A and B are said to be *disjoint*, if $A \cap B = \emptyset$.

Definition 2.21. A *singleton* set is a set consisting of exactly **one** element.

Definition 2.22. Let $P(x)$ be a predicate on a set X . The *set-builder notation*

$$A := \{x \in X : P(x)\}$$

defines A to be the set of precisely those elements $x \in X$ for which $P(x)$ is true. Equivalently, for every $a \in X$,

$$a \in A \iff P(a).$$

Definition 2.23. A set A is a *subset* of a set B if every element of A is also an element of B . We then write $A \subseteq B$. If A is not a subset of B , we write $A \not\subseteq B$; this means that some element of A is not an element of B . If $A \subseteq B$ and $A \neq B$, then A is a *proper subset* of B , written $A \subset B$. Two sets are equal exactly when both containments hold:

$$A = B \iff A \subseteq B \wedge B \subseteq A.$$

Definition 2.24. Let A and B be subsets of a set X .

1. The *union* of A and B is

$$A \cup B := \{x \in X : x \in A \vee x \in B\}.$$

2. The *intersection* of A and B is

$$A \cap B := \{x \in X : x \in A \wedge x \in B\}.$$

3. The *difference* of A and B is

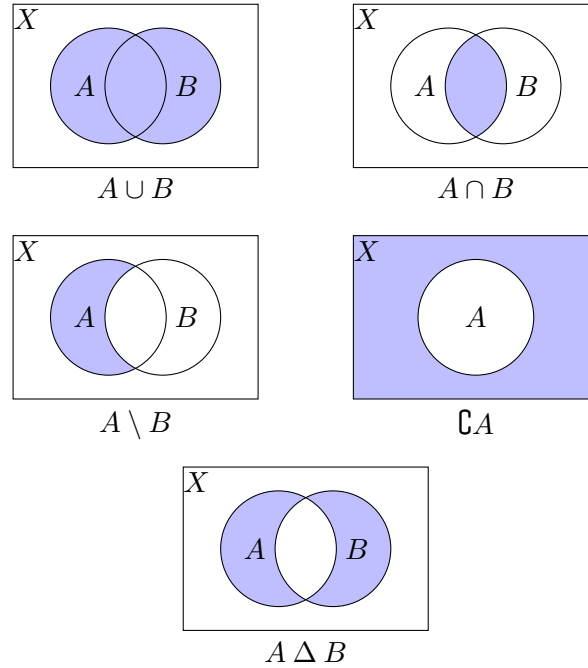
$$A \setminus B := \{x \in X : x \in A \wedge x \notin B\}.$$

4. The *complement* of A in X is

$$\complement A := X \setminus A = \{x \in X : x \notin A\}.$$

5. The *symmetric difference* of A and B is

$$A \Delta B := (A \setminus B) \cup (B \setminus A).$$



2.4 10.09.2026

2.4.1 Power sets

Definition 2.25. The *power set* of a set A , denoted by $\mathcal{P}(A)$, is the set of all subsets of A :

$$\mathcal{P}(A) := \{B : B \subseteq A\}.$$

In particular, $\emptyset \in \mathcal{P}(A)$ and $A \in \mathcal{P}(A)$.

Definition 2.26. Let A and B be sets. Their *Cartesian product* is the set of all ordered pairs whose first component belongs to A and whose second component belongs to B :

$$A \times B := \{(a, b) : a \in A \wedge b \in B\}.$$

More generally, for sets $A_1, \dots, A_n$, their Cartesian product is

$$A_1 \times \dots \times A_n := \{(a_1, \dots, a_n) : a_i \in A_i \text{ for every } i \in \{1, \dots, n\}\}.$$

If all the factors are the same set A , one commonly writes

$$A^n := \underbrace{A \times \dots \times A}_{n \text{ factors}}.$$

Definition 2.27. Let I be a countably infinite *index set*. A family of subsets of a set X , indexed by I , is denoted by $(A_i)_{i \in I}$. Its *union* and *intersection* are defined by

$$\bigcup_{i \in I} A_i := \{x \in X : \exists i \in I, x \in A_i\},$$

$$\bigcap_{i \in I} A_i := \{x \in X : \forall i \in I, x \in A_i\}.$$

Thus, an element belongs to the union if it belongs to at least one of the sets, and it belongs to the intersection if it belongs to every one of them.

If the family itself is denoted by $\mathcal{A} = \{A_i : i \in I\}$, one also writes $\bigcup \mathcal{A}$ and $\bigcap \mathcal{A}$. A common index set is $I = \mathbb{N}$. Since $0 \in \mathbb{N}$ by our convention, one writes

$$\bigcup_{n=0}^{\infty} A_n = \bigcup_{n \in \mathbb{N}} A_n, \quad \bigcap_{n=0}^{\infty} A_n = \bigcap_{n \in \mathbb{N}} A_n.$$

For a family indexed by the positive integers, the corresponding notation is $\bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} A_n$ and $\bigcap_{n=1}^{\infty} A_n$. When the index range is clear from context, these are also abbreviated as $\bigcup_n A_n$ and $\bigcap_n A_n$.

2.4.2 Laws of set algebra

Let A , B , and C be subsets of a universal set X . The union and intersection operations are *commutative*:

$$A \cup B = B \cup A, \quad A \cap B = B \cap A.$$

They are also *associative*:

$$(A \cup B) \cup C = A \cup (B \cup C), \quad (A \cap B) \cap C = A \cap (B \cap C).$$

The *distributive laws* are

$$\begin{aligned} A \cap (B \cup C) &= (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C), \\ A \cup (B \cap C) &= (A \cup B) \cap (A \cup C). \end{aligned}$$

The *De Morgan laws* relate complements to unions and intersections:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{C}(A \cup B) &= \mathbb{C}A \cap \mathbb{C}B, \\ \mathbb{C}(A \cap B) &= \mathbb{C}A \cup \mathbb{C}B. \end{aligned}$$

Finally, set difference can be expressed using intersection and complement:

$$A \setminus B = A \cap \mathbb{C}B.$$

Equivalently, replacing B by C gives

$$A \setminus C = A \cap \mathbb{C}C.$$

Theorem 2.28. *Let A and B be subsets of a universal set X . Then*

$$A \subseteq B \iff \mathbb{C}B \subseteq \mathbb{C}A.$$

Proof. Suppose first that $A \subseteq B$, and let $x \in \mathbb{C}B$. Then $x \notin B$. Since every element of A belongs to B , it follows that $x \notin A$, and hence $x \in \mathbb{C}A$. Therefore $\mathbb{C}B \subseteq \mathbb{C}A$.

Conversely, suppose that $\mathbb{C}B \subseteq \mathbb{C}A$, and let $x \in A$. If $x \notin B$, then $x \in \mathbb{C}B$, so the assumed inclusion would imply that $x \in \mathbb{C}A$, contradicting $x \in A$. Thus $x \in B$, and therefore $A \subseteq B$. $\square$

2.5 14.09.2026

2.5.1 Proof by counterexample

To disprove a universal claim, it is enough to find a single case in which the claim fails. Such a case is called a *counterexample*.

Example 2.29. Consider the claim that

$$(a + b)^2 = a^2 + b^2$$

for all real numbers a and b . Let $a = b = 1$. Then

$$(a + b)^2 = (1 + 1)^2 = 4, \quad a^2 + b^2 = 1^2 + 1^2 = 2.$$

Since $4 \neq 2$, this is a counterexample, and therefore the claim is false.

2.5.2 Proof by contradiction

In a proof by contradiction, we assume that the claim is false and show that this assumption leads to a contradiction.

Example 2.30. Suppose that $A \subseteq B$ and $A \not\subseteq C$. We prove by contradiction that $B \not\subseteq C$.

Assume, to the contrary, that $B \subseteq C$. Since $A \not\subseteq C$, there exists an element $x \in A$ such that $x \notin C$. But $A \subseteq B$ implies that $x \in B$, and $B \subseteq C$ then implies that $x \in C$. This contradicts $x \notin C$. Therefore $B \not\subseteq C$.

2.5.3 Relations

Definition 2.31. A *relation* from a set A to a set B is a subset

$$R \subseteq A \times B.$$

If $(a, b) \in R$, we say that a is related to b and write aRb . A relation on A is a relation from A to itself, that is, a subset of $A \times A$.

Definition 2.32. Let $R \subseteq A \times B$ be a relation. The *inverse relation* of R is

$$R^{-1} = \{(b, a) \in B \times A : (a, b) \in R\}.$$

Equivalently, $bR^{-1}a$ if and only if aRb .

Definition 2.33. Let R be a relation on a set A . The relation R is

1. *reflexive* if xRx for every $x \in A$;
2. *irreflexive* if $(x, x) \notin R$ for every $x \in A$;
3. *symmetric* if, for all $x, y \in A$, xRy implies yRx ;
4. *antisymmetric* if, for all $x, y \in A$, xRy and yRx imply $x = y$;
5. *asymmetric* if, for all $x, y \in A$, xRy implies $(y, x) \notin R$;
6. *transitive* if, for all $x, y, z \in A$, xRy and yRz imply xRz ; and
7. *total* if, for all $x, y \in A$, either xRy or yRx .

A relation is an *equivalence relation* if it is reflexive, symmetric, and transitive.